in the garb of a *qalandar* when even his disguise was pierced. He was caught and sent to the governor of Multan, in whose custody he died. It was this governor who brought Ibrahim's head to Akbar's court.

The governor of Multan arrived in Fatehpur on the same day as the governor of Punjab – Husain Quli Khan. For all those dismissive things about fighting chickens that Akbar had once said of him – and, in fact, for all that his father, Wali Beg, had been killed in Bairam Khan's cause – Husain Quli was becoming one of Akbar's best commanders. It was he who had swept Sharafuddin out of Rajasthan, long ago; and it was he, now, who captured Mirza Ibrahim's younger brother, Masud.

The younger Mirza and some 300 of his men were brought and paraded before Akbar, wrapped in animal hide. In a painting of the scene, the prisoners look like they might be performing a pantomime: dressed as cows and camels, deer and cheetahs and monkeys.[42] In fact, of course, it was a much more macabre affair. Badauni describes the men 'with the skins of asses, hogs, and dogs drawn over their faces', a humiliation that would also have been suffocating torture. Abul Fazl says they were all imprisoned afterwards, but Badauni relates that some of them were killed, and with such 'ingenious tortures' that another Mughal chief – and friend of Badauni's – who had brought 100-odd prisoners of his own along, too, promptly released them all.

News of Mirza Ibrahim's bloody and comprehensive defeat had not reached Gujarat, however – or it made no dent on his estranged brother Muhammad Husain's ambitions. This last remaining Mirza of note[43] forged an alliance with two Gujarati powers – Ikhtiyar-ul-Mulk and the Fuladis – and swooped down upon Ahmedabad.

Akbar had left the city to his milk brother Aziz, who raised Ahmedabad's defences before the enemy could enter. Aziz had enough soldiers to battle them, too; but unfortunately, while Akbar could rely on Aziz, the newly appointed governor of Ahmedabad had no such 'confidence in his own men'.[44] Unable to risk an all-out war in fear of desertions on the battlefield, all Aziz could do was send selected men on ineffective skirmishes – one Sultan Khwaja was unhorsed and fell into the city's moat, from which he had to be rescued in a basket. Thereafter, it seems, Aziz realized a better use for the soldier and sent him to Akbar, asking for urgent help.